

Nikhil Sharma.

Head of Product Design · AI-Native Product Organizations

hi.nikhilsharma@gmail.com · [+91-9999724809](tel:+91-9999724809) · [linkedin.com/in/nikhilsharma09](https://www.linkedin.com/in/nikhilsharma09)

Summary

Head of Product Design with **12+ years** building product organizations, AI-powered design systems, and consumer fintech at scale. Built Airtel Payments Bank's design organization from the ground up into the multidisciplinary team behind products serving **12M+ monthly active users**, and made design a strategic partner across product, engineering, and leadership.

Runs a design function that ships production code through AI-assisted design-to-code pipelines, grounds product decisions in field research across rural and urban India, and has turned customer trust into a marketed differentiator for the bank.

Executive Snapshot

LEADERSHIP

0 to 20 Built Design Function

20+ Direct Design Hires

BUSINESS IMPACT

28× Digital Gold Growth

7× Customer Onboarding Growth

62% Fraud Reduction

85% QA/UAT Effort Reduction

SCALE

12M+ Monthly Active Users

500+ User Interviews, 50 Field Studies

ENTREPRENEURSHIP

₹70L Monthly Revenue (Svenklas)

3 Lakh+ Units Sold

30+ Retail Partners

Enterprise-grade Design Ops SaaS (LANE)

Experience

Airtel Payments Bank

Head of Product Design

Sep 2017 – Present

Built and scaled the Product Design function into a strategic capability across consumer banking, merchant platforms, and AI-enabled product development, partnering with executive leadership on strategy, operating models, and business outcomes.

ORGANIZATIONAL LEADERSHIP

Built Airtel Payments Bank's Product Design function from zero into a **20-person multidisciplinary organization**, establishing hiring, career development, design operations, UX research, and design systems as core organizational capabilities.

Hired **20+ designers** directly at Airtel Payments Bank and mentored **40+** across the industry, building high-performing teams through structured hiring, performance management, and leadership development.

Repositioned Design as a strategic business function by introducing executive design reviews, problem-first product discovery, research-led prioritization, and cross-functional planning with Product, Engineering, Compliance, and Business leadership.

AI TRANSFORMATION & PRODUCT INFRASTRUCTURE

Authored the CEO-approved strategy to make Airtel Payments Bank an **AI-native product organization**, building a **Figma-to-production-code pipeline** (Figma MCP with Claude Code) that lets designers ship production frontend directly, cutting QA/UAT from two weeks to two days.

Built **Vault**, an AI-powered design system spanning consumer and merchant platforms, where 12 designers now ship production code with zero frontend-engineering dependency and **85%** lower QA/UAT effort.

PRODUCT STRATEGY & BUSINESS GROWTH

Led the design strategy for Airtel Payments Bank's standalone banking platform, separating banking from the telecom ecosystem without disrupting an active nationwide customer base.

Designed **Airtel Payments Bank for Business** from inception, a unified merchant platform spanning payments, current accounts, lending, analytics, and business operations, and presented its vision in **board-level strategy reviews**.

Increased first-time digital gold adoption by **28×** by introducing a ₹10-a-day SIP model informed by behavioral research into why casual savers never bought gold.

Increased customer onboarding by **7×** by redesigning activation around behavioral barriers, simplifying KYC, improving recovery flows, and reducing the first deposit requirement from ₹100 to ₹1.

TRUST, SAFETY & CUSTOMER EXPERIENCE

Studied real fraud patterns across the customer base to design both prevention and rapid-response systems for digitally vulnerable, low-literacy users, reducing digital fraud by **62%** in two quarters.

Built contextual, native-language interventions and redesigned recovery journeys that made trust and safety part of the bank's public brand.

Signature Work

Fraud Alarm

One swipe freezes the account, resets credentials, reports the fraud, and triggers a bank callback in a single gesture.

Innovation of the Year. Resolves 39% of frauds.

Transparent Banking

Plain-language view of charges, permissions, data use, and account states for low-literacy customers, adopted bank-wide.

Cut charge-related support calls by 22%.

Safe Pay

India-first third-factor authentication: explicit in-app approval required before any UPI or net-banking debit goes out.

2 industry awards. 32% higher balances.

PayU India

Senior UX Designer

Jul 2016 – Sep 2017

Led end-to-end design for payment experiences across web and mobile, simplifying checkout journeys and reducing customer friction. Partnered with Product Managers and Engineering to improve payment success, merchant onboarding, and customer retention through data-informed design decisions.

GE Healthcare

UX Designer

Jul 2014 – Jul 2016

Designed enterprise healthcare applications supporting clinicians and hospital operations across diagnostic and imaging workflows. Collaborated with cross-functional teams across Product Management and Engineering to simplify high-risk workflows while maintaining regulatory and usability requirements.

Entrepreneurial Ventures

LANE

Founder

AI-native Design Ops SaaS

Building an AI-native design ops platform that takes product teams from ideas to validated decisions: structured problem framing, hypothesis validation, design collaboration, and delivery planning in one place.

PRODUCT CRAFT

Designed, built, and shipped solo end to end on Next.js, Supabase, and the Claude API. AI workflows evaluate hypotheses and requirement quality before a team commits to execution.

Svenklas

Founder

Premium Minimalist Travel Accessories Brand

Built a digitally native lifestyle brand focused on premium backpacks and travel accessories.

BUSINESS IMPACT

Scaled to ₹70L monthly revenue and 3 lakh+ units sold across online and offline channels. Expanded distribution through 30+ retail partners, bootstrapped with no external funding.

Leadership & Expertise

LEADERSHIP

Organizational Design
Product Strategy
Design Leadership
Executive Stakeholder Management

PRODUCT

Consumer Fintech
Growth & Activation
Trust & Safety
Behavioral Design

AI & DESIGN

Design-to-Code Pipelines
Design Systems
Design Operations
UX Research

TECHNOLOGY

Figma
Claude Code & Cursor
Next.js & React
Supabase & Vercel

Education

Bachelor of Architecture

National Institute of Technology, Hamirpur · 2005 – 2010

Awards

Innovation of the Year, Finnoviti Awards (Fraud Alarm)
Best Digital Banking Initiative, Digital Banker Awards
Best Payments Experience, Asiamoney Awards

Beyond work Music producer and multi-instrumentalist, watercolourist, and lifelong maths enthusiast, currently exploring documentary filmmaking.